

THE LANGUAGE OF THE PRIESTLY SOURCE AND ITS HISTORICAL SETTING — THE CASE FOR AN EARLY DATE*

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I

Any attempt to date the Priestly Source must approach the problem from every possible aspect, including the linguistic one. Within the framework of the latter aspect, particularly significant is the study of diachronic distinctions between pre-exilic (=classical) and post-exilic (=post-classical) BH, since the differentiation between the two epochs is the key element for the dating of P. The existence of these linguistic distinctions within BH was recognized long ago by various scholars.¹ However, the *Forschungsgeschichte* of P reveals that, for the most part, Biblical Criticism has not fully exploited the potential of this approach. In the nineteenth century, on the one hand, an abundance of studies appeared which endeavored to discover "late" idioms and expressions all over the Bible; yet methodologically these attempts hardly meet the high standards required by modern scholarship. The twentieth century, on the other hand, has placed at our disposal the tools for examining the entire subject of LBH systematically. Unfortunately, however, ever since the discovery of the Ugaritic literary treasures many biblical scholars who deal with language and style have been preoccupied with the early, rather than the later, strata of BH. Consequently, all too many *biblicists* have failed to take full advantage of the important achievements gained by the *linguists'* study of the formation and development of the later historical phases of the Hebrew language — both in biblical and post-biblical sources.

The exploitation of this somewhat neglected common ground between

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1. See, for example, the lists of words and forms in W. Gesenius, *Geschichte der hebräischen Sprache und Schrift*, published as early as 1815. Also of great importance in this regard are the lists of LBH (=Late Biblical Hebrew) elements compiled by S.R. Driver in his *An Introduction to the Literature of the Old Testament*.

the Bible and linguistics turned out in recent years to be most fruitful for the study of various texts of chronologically disputable nature. The specific contribution of this linguistic approach to the search for P's historical setting will be our concern in the following paper.

II

The two major phases of BH referred to above — “classical” and “post-classical” — represent, on the one hand, the literature of the “Golden Age” (which coincides with the First Commonwealth period) and, on the other, that of the “Silver Age” (which represents the Second Temple period).² In historical terms, then, the border line between these two successive stages of BH is clearly demarcated by the Babylonian Exile of the sixth century B.C.E. — which was a decisive turning point in the whole of Israelite history. During this century the intensive contact between Hebrew and Aramaic was unparalleled in scope and magnitude; it was then that LBH came into being.³

LBH, which is most clearly manifested in the Hagiographic books of Ecclesiastes, Esther, Daniel, Ezra-Nehemiah, and Chronicles, has its own distinctive linguistic profile; it is readily distinguishable from the classical language employed in the earlier sections of the Bible in all three major aspects of vocabulary, grammar, and syntax.⁴ Furthermore, the numerous neologisms introduced into the language by late BH may be viewed as signs of the linguistic “decline” of classical BH (hence the term “*Silver Age*”). Therefore, it should come as no surprise that over the years

2. For these terms cf., for instance, Gesenius, *op. cit.*, p. 21; H.L. Ginsberg, “The Northwest Semitic Languages,” in B. Mazar, ed., *The World History of the Jewish People*, First Series: Ancient Times, Vol. II [Patriarchs], (Tel Aviv, 1970), p. 112.

3. Cf. E.Y. Kutscher, *A History of the Hebrew Language* (Jerusalem, 1982), §§100–106 (“The Aramaic Influence”), pp. 71–77; §§117–123 (“Late Biblical Hebrew”), pp. 81–84.

4. For studies dealing specifically with LBH cf. the following three books: A. Kropat, *Die Syntax des Autors der Chronik verglichen mit der seiner Quellen* (Giessen, 1909) [=BZAW, XVI]; A. Hurvitz, *The Transition Period in Biblical Hebrew — A Study in Post-Exilic Hebrew and its Implications for the Dating of Psalms* (Jerusalem, 1972) [in Hebrew]; R. Polzin, *Late Biblical Hebrew — Toward an Historical Typology of Biblical Hebrew Prose* (Missoula, Montana, 1976) [=Harvard Semitic Monographs, XII]. See also Ch. Rabin, “Hebrew,” in T.A. Sebeok, ed., *Current Trends in Linguistics*, Vol. VI (1970), pp. 316–317; *idem*, “Hebrew and Aramaic in the First Century,” in S. Safrai et alii, eds., *The Jewish People in the First Century* [=Compendia Rerum Iudaicarum ad Novum Testamentum], Vol. II (Assen/Amsterdam, 1976), pp. 1014–1015.

repeated attempts have been made to detect traces of this “decadent” style within P — which is widely considered among scholars to be a late composition, reflecting the exilic and/or post-exilic period. One of the famous early studies to take this approach was F. Giesebrecht’s detailed **essay**, “Zur Hexateuchkritik. Der Sprachgebrauch des hexateuchischen Elohisten,” published in the first volume of *ZAW*.⁵ Giesebrecht concluded that “Von Spuren höchsten Alters findet sich nichts in ihm, wohl aber weisen eine Reihe sehr signifikanter Züge auf die silberne Literaturperiode hin”⁶ — a conclusion which received the endorsement of “The Master,” J. Wellhausen.⁷ Similar views were also expressed at that time by such leading biblical critics as A. Kuenen and W. Robertson Smith. Kuenen asserted that “Linguistic comparisons... furnish a very strong presumption against the theory that the priestly laws were written in the golden age of Israelitish literature”;⁸ Robertson Smith stated that “the priestly style is... deficient, as compared with the older narratives.”⁹ Arguing in circle, the allegedly “inferior” style of P was then adduced as additional confirmation of the prevailing view that P was a product of the late biblical period.

The hypothesis of the late character of P’s language was influenced by some general misconceptions about the nature and correct interpretation of the so-called “Aramaisms” in BH as a whole. According to the then current view, the mere existence of Aramaic counterparts for certain Hebrew words could be taken as sufficient evidence that the said Hebrew words were “Aramaisms,” i.e., that they were (1) of Aramaic origin and (2) of late date.¹⁰ As soon as they were published, these uncritical attitudes were criticized by competent Hebraists and Semitists such as S.R. Driver¹¹

5. *ZAW* 1 (1881), pp. 177–276.

6. *Ibid.*, p. 269.

7. J. Wellhausen, *Prolegomena to the History of Ancient Israel* ([Edinburgh, 1885] New York, 1957), p. 389.

8. A. Kuenen, *An Historico-Critical Inquiry into the Origin and Composition of the Hexateuch* (London, 1886), p. 291.

9. W. Robertson Smith, *The Old Testament in the Jewish Church* (London and Edinburgh, 1892), p. 408.

10. The standard treatment of the subject published in those years was E. Kautzsch, *Die Aramaismen im Alten Testament* (Halle, 1902).

11. *Journal of Philology* 11 (1882), pp. 201–236 (a review of Giesebrecht [cf. above, n. 5]).

and Th. Nöldeke.¹² But it was not until more recent years, after the immense progress in Northwest Semitic and Aramaic studies in particular, that the falseness of these views could be conclusively demonstrated.¹³ In light of newly discovered texts¹⁴ and fresh studies,¹⁵ we are in a much better position today to determine which linguistic elements within BH are late.¹⁶ A new perspective, the linguistic-diachronic, was thus created for examining the cultic language of P — whose chronological background and historical setting are disputed. This attempt did indeed prove to be a challenge not only to the critical analysis of P, but to the historical study of Biblical Hebrew as well.¹⁷

III

Our first test case in examining the linguistic background of P's characteristic terminology was an analysis of the pair of terms **שש** and **בני**.¹⁸ This analysis demonstrated that whereas P employs the ancient term **שש** exclusively, the later **בני**, which is predominant in all the available post-classical sources (biblical and non-biblical, Hebrew and Aramaic), did not manage to penetrate it even once. P was, so to speak, "immune" to the expression which was typical of the late period. Needless to say, this single example could not be considered conclusive testimony to anything beyond

12. *ZDMG* 57 (1903), pp. 412–420 (a review of Kautzsch [cf. above, n. 10]).

13. Regrettably, however, these outdated notions about "Aramaisms" are still held by some modern scholars. Cf. J.C. Greenfield, *JBL* 87 (1968), pp. 232–234, a review of M. Wagner, *Die lexikalischen und grammatikalischen Aramaismen im alttestamentlichen Hebräisch* (Berlin, 1966) [=BZAW, XCVI]. For the whole matter cf. also E.Y. Kutscher, "Aramaic," in *Current Trends...* (above, n. 4), pp. 358–360.

14. Most important amongst these are the Dead Sea Scrolls. Cf. Ch. Rabin, "The Historical Background of Qumran Hebrew," *Scripta Hierosolymitana*, Vol. IV (1958), pp. 144–161; E.Y. Kutscher, *The Language and Linguistic Background of the Isaiah Scroll* (Jerusalem, 1959) [in Hebrew; an English translation of the book appeared in Leiden in 1979 (StTDJ, VI)]; E. Qimron, *A Grammar of the Hebrew Language of the Dead Sea Scrolls* (Jerusalem, 1976) [in Hebrew; a Ph.D. thesis submitted to the Hebrew University of Jerusalem].

15. Cf. particularly A. Bendavid, *Biblical Hebrew and Mishnaic Hebrew* (Tel Aviv, 1967–) [in Hebrew].

16. Cf. A. Hurvitz, "The Chronological Significance of 'Aramaisms' in Biblical Hebrew," *IEJ* 18 (1968), pp. 234–240; *idem*, *Beyn Lashon Lelashon* (above, n. 4), pp. 13–63.

17. Cf. Ch. Rabin, *Leshonenu* 39 (1974–5), p. 182 [in Hebrew].

18. A. Hurvitz, "The Usage of **שש** and **בני** in the Bible and its Implication for the Date of P," *HThR* 60 (1967), pp. 117–121.

itself; but it did justify further investigations along the same lines. Above all, it has clearly shown that internal distinctions observed within the Priestly terminology — employed both in the Pentateuch and outside it — may be correlated with linguistic developments which took place in the course of the history of BH as a whole.

In a subsequent study, undertaken from a somewhat different angle, the term *עֲדָה* was examined.¹⁹ Here, too, our analysis suggested that the chronological significance of the appearance of the Priestly *עֲדָה* within the Bible is the reverse of that suggested by those who assign a late date to P. The linguistic background reflected in the biblical texts using this term is, in fact, indicative of the earlier period, well before the Israelites went into Exile.

A further investigation, utilizing additional examples drawn from P and examining broader linguistic aspects, appeared in 1974.²⁰ It included an analysis of nine characteristic terms and expressions which represent a highly variegated cross-section of the Priestly vocabulary. These words are used in connection with genealogical lists (*וְלִמְעֵלָה* ... *מִן*; *הַתַּיִחַס*); sacrificial regulations (*קָבַל*; *הָדִיחַ*); religious offerings and services (*הַתְּנִיב*); technical descriptions of cultic objects, structures, and activities (*קָבַיב*; *קָבִיב*; *חֲפָה*); cloth used for sacred purposes (*בִּיץ* [cf. above]); and designations of Temple *loci* (*עֲזָרָה*).²¹ The analysis of all these terms clearly reaffirmed our earlier results. It showed that:

(1) The linguistic differences noted between P on the one hand, and Ezekiel, Ezra-Nehemiah, and Chronicles on the other, are due to chronological distinctions between early BH and late BH;

(2) P is invariably faithful to the early language, never resorting to any of the Priestly terms peculiar to the late literature — both in the Bible (Ez., Ezra-Neh., Ch.) and outside (Rabbinic literature in Hebrew and Aramaic alike).

Our suggestion that P should be assigned to the earlier rather than the later biblical period was thus based on two complementary facts:

(1) *The absence* from P of the terminology and phraseology employed

19. *Idem*, "Linguistic Observations on the Biblical Usage of the Priestly Term 'edah' (*עֲדָה*)," *Tarbiz* 40 (1970-1), pp. 261-267 [in Hebrew; for an English presentation see *Immanuel*, A Semi-Annual Bulletin of Religious Thought and Research in Israel, No. 1. (1972), pp. 21-23].

20. *Idem*, "The Evidence of Language in Dating the Priestly Code — A Linguistic Study in Technical Idioms and Terminology," *RB* 81 (1974), pp. 24-56.

21. *Ibid.*, p. 47.

throughout the distinctively late sources to express fundamental Priestly concepts, institutions, and regulations;

(2) *The existence* in P of an alternative set of expressions and phrases for the same Priestly matters — a set whose background, on linguistic grounds, can be shown to be pre-exilic.^{21*}

This being the case, we concluded that: "What there is in P is early (=pre-exilic) and what is missing is distinctively late (=exilic and post-exilic). The evidence of language thus demonstrates that P does not reflect nor anticipate the situations and conditions which characterize the exilic and post-exilic period . . . P's 'historical horizon' (Kaufmann) and its *Sitz im Leben* (Gunkel) are definitely indicative of the pre-exilic period."²² Nonetheless, we did not exclude the possibility that future investigations may present additional data which might require some modification in our conclusions.²³ Such data were indeed adduced independently in 1976 by R. Polzin²⁴ and B. Levine.²⁵ We shall now turn, therefore, to an evaluation of these two studies.

IV

R. Polzin argues that the language of P is later than classical BH, although it still antedates LBH. Also, within P itself, Polzin finds distinctions which reflect, according to his view, two linguistically successive phases — that of P⁸ (=the original *Grundschrift* of P) and that of P^s (=the later layer of P). According to this conception, then, P — which in itself represents a sequence of two different linguistic stages — reflects the transition period between classical BH and late BH.²⁶

21*. The reader should note that although our conclusions are naturally based on the *absence* of late elements from the texts of P under discussion, we employ a line of investigation which is methodologically entirely different from the oft-criticized *argumentum ex silentio* approach. Had we followed the latter, the very absence of a given word from a text would be taken as decisive proof that the word did not exist at the time when the text was composed. By contrast, our method views the absence of a word from a given text as only *one* of a *whole series* of possible criteria of lateness. Cf. the studies referred to above in n. 16.

22. *Ibid.*, p. 54.

23. *Ibid.*, p. 55.

24. Cf. above, n. 4.

25. "Priestly Writers," in: *The Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible*, Supplementary Volume (Nashville, 1976), p. 685.

26. "... the grammatical/syntactic nature of P⁸ and P^s places them between classical BH

To be sure, Polzin's study goes beyond the limits which we set for ourselves in *RB*.²⁷ His wider interest is shown in his (1) treatment of *non-technical* features; (2) analysis of *grammatical/syntactical* peculiarities; (3) examination of *internal distinctions* within P. Hence this approach constitutes a welcome contribution to the illumination of the problem. Yet the crucial question is whether we can readily accept his actual analysis and suggested results; and in this regard some serious reservations have already been expressed.²⁸ The whole matter cannot, of course, be discussed here at length. Suffice it to say at this juncture that in order to reach a final decision on the relative age of the language of P, one must also consider the language of the Book of Ezekiel. For Ezekiel is our most — in fact, our only — certain representative of that part of biblical literature composed in Priestly circles during the exilic period.²⁹ Furthermore, typologically it is the Book of Ezekiel which seems to best represent the linguistic bridge between classical BH and late BH.³⁰ If it is argued, therefore, that P's language reflects the same historical period and chronological framework as Ezekiel's, then the languages of both compositions must somehow be related and compared.

In *RB* we did in fact make use of data drawn from the Book of Ezekiel and, we believe, the results of that study have clearly shown, that — linguistically speaking — P is not only *pre-LBH* (as Polzin agrees), but *pre-Ezekiel* as well.³¹ However, the comparison of P with Ez. constituted only a relatively small part of that analysis. It was only in a more recent study, devoted specifically to this topic, that we made the linguistic equation between P and Ez. the central focus of the whole investigation.³² This study and the LBH of Chronicles. Moreover, the data suggest that P^s is typologically later than P⁸ (Polzin, *op. cit.*, p. 112). Prof. Polzin has kindly informed me that similar results have been reached in a new Ph.D. thesis (A.R. Guenther, *A Diachronic Study of Biblical Hebrew Prose Syntax*) submitted recently to the University of Toronto.

27. Cf. above, n. 20.

28. For a detailed review of Polzin's book, cf. G. Rendsburg's article in *JANES* 12 (1980), pp. 65–80, as well as our remarks in the study mentioned above (n. *), pp. 163–171.

29. "the majority of the recent writers leave the prophet in the sixth century B.C.," "in the period immediately before and after the fall of Jerusalem" (H.H. Rowley, "The Book of Ezekiel in Modern Study," *BJRL* 36 [1953–54], pp. 163 and 190 respectively). Cf. also P.R. Ackroyd, *Exile and Restoration* (Philadelphia, 1968), p. 103.

30. Cf. Gesenius, *op. cit.*, (above, n. 1), p. 35; Hurvitz, *op. cit.* (above, n. 20), p. 47, n. 41; Rabin, *Hebrew and Aramaic* . . . (above, n. 4), pp. 1012–13.

31. Hurvitz, *op. cit.* (above, n. 30).

32. Cf. above n. *.

includes an analysis of 30 Priestly terms and expressions along the following lines:

- (1) Elements present in P, for which there are no parallels at all in the corresponding passages of Ezekiel;
- (2) Elements present in Ezekiel, for which there are no parallels at all in the corresponding passages of P;
- (3) Elements found in one of the two, for which there are alternative elements in the corresponding passages of the other.

The examples were drawn from legal as well as non-legal texts, and the linguistic elements themselves include lexical and grammatical aspects. Our final conclusions as to the linguistic relationship between P and Ez. were:

- (1) "The linguistic data . . . clearly strengthen the case of those who place P *prior* to Ez. Whatever the *absolute* dating of P and Ezekiel, then, it can definitely be stated that P comes first in a *relative* chronological order."³³
- (2) "Since it is Ez. which (within biblical literature) best represents the age of the exile, it follows that P should be seen as substantially pre-exilic."³⁴

V

The second scholar who has suggested that the language of P betrays late elements is B. Levine. His thesis is elaborated now at length in "To the Study of the Priestly Source — The Linguistic Aspect."³⁵ In this article מִשְׁחָה and דָּגַל were treated in detail; and there are additional terms which Levine interprets as linguistic elements reflecting the late biblical period.³⁶ However, for the sake of brevity we shall limit our discussion here to מִשְׁחָה and דָּגַל:

- (1) מִשְׁחָה — Levine suggests that the word was probably unknown "prior to the destruction of the First Commonwealth and Exile."³⁷ However, as he himself admits the possibility that the word did exist

33. *Ibid.*, p. 155.

34. *Ibid.*, p. 170.

35. *Eretz Israel*, Vol. XVI [=H.M. Orlinsky Jubilee Volume] (Jerusalem, 1982), pp. 124–131 (Hebrew). I wish to express my deepest gratitude to Prof. Levine for placing the manuscript of his paper at my disposal.

36. For instance, מִקְדָּשׁ — for which cf. below, n. 45.

37. Levine, *op. cit.* (above, n. 35), p. 127.

already "at the *end* [my italics — A.H.] of the First Commonwealth,"³⁸ this would still leave us within the classical framework of pre-exilic Hebrew ("the *First Commonwealth*"). Hence I see no conflict whatsoever between our positions. It is clear that even according to Levine's own interpretation מִשְׁחָה is totally inconclusive evidence for arguing an exilic/post-exilic date for P.

(2) דָּגַל — This example, one must admit, is very impressive. In fact, it is the best evidence Levine has provided so far in favor of his theory, as the word has, indeed, strong documentation from the fifth century B.C.E. onwards (particularly in the Elephantine Aramaic papyri). However, as Levine himself notes, דָּגַל cannot be etymologically dissociated from the Akkadogram *bēl madgalti* = "commander of the border guards,"^{38*} attested in Hittite texts of the second millennium B.C.E.: "Both terms, [Akkad.] (*bēl*) *madgalti* and [Heb.] *degel*, are derived from one and the same root and much the same basic conception underlies them both."³⁹ Furthermore, regarding the ultimate source of *bēl madgalti*, Levine accepts the suggestion that "undoubtedly its origin is to be sought in ancient Syria" and that "it belongs to the peripheral lexicon."⁴⁰ If this is indeed the case — as we, too, are inclined to think — then our Heb. דָּגַל has a long and venerable past. Both from the standpoint of chronology (2nd millennium B.C.E.) and semantics (military connotation), its antiquity may be established on the basis of extra-biblical sources!

Baruch Levine has posed the following interesting questions: why is it that "the term דָּגַל is unknown from any other biblical source except the Book of Numbers" and "has no trace in any of the passages dealing with military operations and wars recorded in Samuel and Kings"?⁴¹ These questions are not easy to answer; however, they are not unique or specific to the case of דָּגַל alone. On the contrary, the language of the Priestly Source as a whole is characterized by numerous linguistic and stylistic peculiarities which are not shared by standard BH. Yet their absence from the non-Priestly sections of classical biblical literature does not in any way

38. *Ibid.*

38*. Cf. M. Weinfeld, "Judge and Officer in Ancient Israel and in the Ancient Near East," *IOS* 7 (1977), p. 77.

39. Levine, *op. cit.*, p. 128.

40. *Ibid.*

41. *Ibid.*, p. 129.

imply that they are necessarily late novelties within the history of BH.⁴² In any event, the case of דגל is of the utmost importance not only for the discussion of the term itself but because of its far-reaching implications. It illustrates once again⁴³ the methodological pitfalls involved in the study of supposedly late Aramaic influences upon Hebrew: we must always bear in mind that although the Elephantine papyri were *written down* in the fifth century B.C.E., the language employed in these texts was not *created* suddenly in the Persian period. This is particularly true of technical terminology, legal and otherwise, preserved in the texts. Indeed, scholars who have dealt with this issue emphasize the “intermediary role” which the Aramaic of Elephantine and elsewhere played in the cultural history of the entire ancient Near East.⁴⁴ It is, therefore, perfectly clear that Elephantine Aramaic on the one hand and Biblical Hebrew on the other, even when exhibiting similar (or identical) linguistic usages, could have drawn, independently and at different times, on a common third source, earlier than both.⁴⁵ The Priestly term דגל discussed above would seem to be just

42. Cf. Driver, *op. cit.* (above, n. 11), pp. 220–221, 232–233. Note that Levine himself also pursues this line of reasoning in his discussion of the cultic(!) term נְתִינִים (*JBL* 82 [1963], pp. 207–212). Although the word is recorded in biblical literature only in post-exilic writings, Levine argues that the term — as well as the cultic guild it denotes — are pre-exilic: “In view of the fact that the pre-exilic sources do not mention the *netinim*, is this tradition of I Chronicles reliable? The absence of this term from the earlier sources should not trouble us. The books of Samuel and Kings also fail to mention other groups of temple personnel . . .” (*ibid.*, p. 208).

43. Cf. above, p. 86.

44. “Aramaic played the role of clearing house between Orient and Occident” (Kutscher, *op. cit.* [n. 13], p. 384); Official Aramaic (700 B.C.E.–300 B.C.E.) served “as a medium of transmission and distribution of legal terms” (*ibid.*, p. 385); “The Aramaic formulary was based on cuneiform prototypes but was strongly influenced by [ancient — A.H.] West Semitic legal and business terminology” (Y. Muffs, *Studies in the Aramaic Legal Papyri from Elephantine* [Leiden, 1969] [=Studia et Documenta, VIII], p. 6 [following M. Lidzbarski]); “the Elephantine formulary, with its Western linguistic orientation, must be, at least in part, a reflex of . . . Old Aramaic formulary” (*ibid.*, p. 196); “the ancient vocabulary of Aramaic included not only genuine Aramaic elements, but also old Western ones whose origins go back to ancient Amorite and the Akkadian in use in Syria in relatively early periods” (B. Levine, *op. cit.* [above, n. 35]), p. 125.

45. Cf., for instance, the case of the Priestly מִכְסֵּה, which must ultimately derive from Akkadian *miksu*. Both Wagner (*op. cit.* [above, n. 13], p. 76) and Levine (*op. cit.* [above, n. 35], p. 131, n. 30) assume that the word reached Hebrew, *via* Aramaic, only in the late biblical period; but the word “could just as well have entered Canaanite during the Amarna age when Akkadian was the *lingua franca*” (Greenfield, *op. cit.* [above, n. 13], p. 233).

such a case, in light of the attestation of the closely related (*bēl*) *madgalti* as early as the 2nd millennium B.C.E.⁴⁶

VI

We have seen that the language of the Priestly Source presents exceedingly difficult problems, and the possibilities for its investigation are as yet far from being exhausted. Every attempt to throw additional light on its history and development is thus most welcome. However, we must always bear in mind that the biblical texts cannot be loaded with more than they actually contain, and that the use of the critical tools at our disposal have objective limits. This is true particularly in the case of P, since the highly technical nature of its subject matter and the esoteric tendencies of its writers raise numerous methodological difficulties. For these reasons it is imperative that we make the necessary *internal Hebrew* comparisons (between P on the one hand and LBH and Ezekiel on the other) our basic point of departure.⁴⁷ Diachronic discussions which attempt to discover historical linguistic developments within biblical literature inevitably require that:

(1) At least two sets of biblical texts be compared (for a *relative* dating);

(2) At least one of these two sets have a firm chronological basis to serve as a control (for *absolute* dating).

Otherwise we may be misled by superficial similarities which might result in mistaken judgements.

46. After noting that "Aramaic included not only genuine Aramaic elements, but also old Western ones whose origins go back to ancient Amorite" (cf. above, n. 44) Levine goes on to say that "These components are termed peripheral and were transmitted neither through the standard channels of the Assyrian and Babylonian literature in Mesopotamia proper nor through Biblical Hebrew. They were probably preserved in Aramaic and various Western dialects. Only in later times did they reappear, particularly in Imperial Aramaic of the Achaemenid period, and it was through this channel that they penetrated Hebrew" (*ibid.*). This general description of the peripheral linguistic elements has much to recommend itself. However, if one wishes to exclude BH from that group of "various Western dialects" which did preserve the Western vocabulary of the early period, *conclusive* evidence to that effect must be provided. In the case of דגל, I am afraid, this was not done.

47. Cf. above, pp. 86–88. Needless to say, *internal Aramaic* comparisons of words and expressions are similarly indispensable in order to argue that one or another Aramaic element is "late" within the history of Aramaic itself.

This fact was emphasized long ago by one of the greatest biblical philologists to have dealt with the language of P — S.R. Driver. And it is fitting that we quote here his remarks: “The Elohist [=P] writes technically from beginning to end: he introduces us to a side of the Hebrew language with which, but for him, we should be most imperfectly acquainted: it is instructive to note his vocabulary, but great care must be exercised in interpreting its coincidences with the later Hebrew style.”⁴⁸

Bearing this observation in mind — and relying on the linguistic analysis presented above — we conclude that, barring new evidence to the contrary, the Priestly sections of the Pentateuch should be seen as a product of the “Golden Age” of biblical literature, i.e., as reflecting (substantially) Priestly traditions of the First Temple period.

48. S.R. Driver, *op. cit.* (above, n. 11), p. 217.